

Bill Gates' best tech idea

Why "good enough" software beat perfect products

By **Madhav Banka** | editor@digit.in



“

If you give people tools, and they use their natural abilities and their curiosity, they will develop things in ways that will surprise you very much beyond what you might have expected. Most people overestimate what they can do in one year and underestimate what they can do in ten years. If you can't make it good, at least make it look good.

”

Love it or hate it, but Microsoft's Windows has been a household name since the dawn of modern personal computing. As of 2025, it runs on over a billion devices globally, and there's no stopping it from growing even more. But how did Microsoft even manage to do all this?

Well, Microsoft's secret sauce has always been speed. In his 1999 book, *The Speed of Thought*, Bill Gates said, "Success today requires the agility and drive to constantly rethink, rein-vigorate, react, and reinvent." Clearly, this has been the driving force behind Microsoft's global success.

While competitors like Apple have always been keen to lock in perfection, Microsoft, on the other hand, has always won by setting the standard as fast as possible. The truth is, in the ever-evolving digital age, unfortunately, slow and steady may not always win the race.

Microsoft began in the early MS-DOS days and dominated the market starting in the 1990s, a trend that continues to this date. Here's how Microsoft and Bill Gates' theory of how the "Good Enough" but fast shipped software beats the perfect products every single time.

"Speed" is the competitive advantage

The reason behind Microsoft's dominance in the market has always been that a "Good Enough" product will always beat the great but late ones. Gates recognised early on that in this evolving industry, if you always wait for a product to be 100% perfect, any competitor, even one with a product that achieves only 70% of the goal, will have already captured the market. Genius level thinking!

Microsoft, from its early days, started following this theory, and instead of polishing every possible thing, it focused on speed and shipping the software as early as possible. They used all the feedback they could get after and integrated it into future iterations. This can be seen from the 1990s, when they launched 5 operating systems within a single decade.

Starting from Windows 3.0 in 1990, they were on a roll for the next few years. They were so focused on shipping the products fast that they released the iconic Windows 95 just a few years later! Learning from customer feedback, they quickly started working and integrated the same with Windows 98. During this time,